

CLC

Educational Institute

DIGITAL SAT • READING & WRITING

Expression of Ideas

Theory + 19 Worked Questions • 2 Skills

1. Rhetorical Synthesis

2. Transitions

SECTION 1

Rhetorical Synthesis

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Rhetorical Synthesis

These questions give you a set of student notes and a writing task. You choose the answer that best serves that specific task using only the information in the notes. Across the real question bank, the notes run 1–7 sentences long, but the large majority — 60% — give you exactly 5 notes to work with, so budget your reading time expecting a short list, not a paragraph.

How to Approach

Step 1 — Clarify the objective. Read the question prompt closely — it states the exact outcome required: highlighting a similarity, a contrast, supporting a specific argument, explaining a cause. Underline or mentally flag the task verb and its object before you look at a single answer choice.

Step 2 — Evaluate the options. Examine each option and ignore grammatical correctness. Judge each choice purely on whether it accomplishes the stated goal, using Rule 1 and Rule 2 below.

Step 3 — Confirm by elimination. Systematic elimination against the task, not a search for the "best-sounding" sentence, is what narrows four plausible-looking choices to one correct answer.

Three Rules to Apply on Every Question

Rule 1 — No new information.

The correct answer must use only information from the student's notes. If an answer introduces a fact, statistic, or idea not in the notes, eliminate it immediately — even if it sounds convincing or is probably true in real life.

Rule 2 — Specific detail only counts when it serves the task.

The notes may include names, percentages, dates, and study citations. A correct answer uses those details only when they actively support the stated goal. Specific detail for its own sake is not automatically better — it must be relevant to what the question actually asks for.

Rule 3 — Match the stated purpose exactly.

Every question states the student's exact purpose: "supporting an argument," "highlighting a difference," "providing evidence for a claim." An answer that uses good, accurate evidence for a different purpose than the one named is still wrong.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Rhetorical Synthesis — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Medium

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Elizabeth Catlett’s sculpture *Recognition* (1970) shows two African American figures with rounded, indistinct features.
- The figures reach out to each other in a pose that symbolizes a close, supportive relationship.
- Her sculpture *Students Aspire* (1978) shows two African American figures with sharply defined features.
- The figures hold an equal sign above their heads with one hand and embrace each other with the other hand.
- This pose symbolizes their support for each other in the pursuit of equality.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the two sculptures. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** Catlett’s *Students Aspire* depicts two figures supporting each other in the pursuit of equality.
- B.** *Recognition* and *Students Aspire* both show African American figures in poses that symbolize supportive relationships.
- C.** Catlett completed *Recognition* in 1970 and *Students Aspire* in 1978.
- D.** The figures in *Recognition* have features that are rounded and indistinct, while the figures in *Students Aspire* have sharply defined features.

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is B. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the sculptures Recognition and Students Aspire, noting that both sculptures show African American figures in poses that symbolize supportive relationships.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The sentence describes one of the sculptures; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two sculptures.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Catlett's Students Aspire depicts two figures supporting each other in the pursuit of equality.	Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes one of the sculptures; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two sculptures.
✓ B	Recognition and Students Aspire both show African American figures in poses that symbolize supportive relationships.	Choice B is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the sculptures Recognition and Students Aspire, noting that both sculptures show African American figures in poses that symbolize supportive relationships.
X C	Catlett completed Recognition in 1970 and Students Aspire in 1978.	Choice C is incorrect. The sentence specifies the different years the sculptures were completed in; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two sculptures.
X D	The figures in Recognition have features that are rounded and indistinct, while the figures in Students Aspire have sharply defined features.	Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a difference between the two sculptures, noting that the figures in the sculptures have different feature definition; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two sculptures.

Question 2

Medium

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Cities tend to have a wide range of flowering vegetation in parks, yards, and gardens.
- This vegetation provides a varied diet for honeybees, strengthening bees' immune systems.
- On average, 62.5 percent of bees in an urban area will survive a harsh winter.
- Rural areas are often dominated by monoculture crops such as corn or wheat.
- On average, only 40 percent of honeybees in a rural area will survive a harsh winter.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about honeybees. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** Cities tend to have a wider range of flowering vegetation than do rural areas, which are often dominated by monoculture crops.
- B.** In urban areas, over 60 percent of honeybees, on average, will survive a harsh winter, whereas in rural areas, only 40 percent will.
- C.** The strength of honeybees' immune systems depends on what the bees eat, and a varied diet is more available to bees in an urban area than to those in a rural area.
- D.** Honeybees are more likely to thrive in cities than in rural areas because the varied diet available in urban areas strengthens the bees' immune systems.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is D. the sentence makes and supports a generalization about honeybees. It claims that honeybees living in urban areas are more likely to thrive than rural bees, and it supports the claim with information about the effect of a varied diet on urban bees' immune systems.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: While the sentence makes a generalization, it doesn't mention honeybees.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Cities tend to have a wider range of flowering vegetation than do rural areas, which are often dominated by monoculture crops.	Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence makes a generalization, it doesn't mention honeybees.
X B	In urban areas, over 60 percent of honeybees, on average, will survive a harsh winter, whereas in rural areas, only 40 percent will.	Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence provides data about honeybee survival, it doesn't make a generalization about honeybees based on this information.
X C	The strength of honeybees' immune systems depends on what the bees eat, and a varied diet is more available to bees in an urban area than to those in a rural area.	Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence makes a generalization about honeybees' diets and immune systems, it doesn't provide adequate support for this generalization.
✓ D	Honeybees are more likely to thrive in cities than in rural areas because the varied diet available in urban areas strengthens the bees' immune systems.	Choice D is the best answer because the sentence makes and supports a generalization about honeybees. It claims that honeybees living in urban areas are more likely to thrive than rural bees, and it supports the claim with information about the effect of a varied diet on urban bees' immune systems.

Question 3

Medium

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Soo Sunny Park is a Korean American artist who uses light as her primary medium of expression.
- She created her work Unwoven Light in 2013.
- Unwoven Light featured a chain-link fence fitted with iridescent plexiglass tiles.
- When light passed through the fence, colorful prisms formed.

The student wants to describe Unwoven Light to an audience unfamiliar with Soo Sunny Park. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** Park's 2013 installation Unwoven Light, which included a chain-link fence and iridescent tiles made from plexiglass, featured light as its primary medium of expression.
- B.** Korean American light artist Soo Sunny Park created Unwoven Light in 2013.
- C.** The chain-link fence in Soo Sunny Park's Unwoven Light was fitted with tiles made from iridescent plexiglass.
- D.** In Unwoven Light, a 2013 work by Korean American artist Soo Sunny Park, light formed colorful prisms as it passed through a fence Park had fitted with iridescent tiles.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is D. The sentence effectively describes Unwoven Light to an audience unfamiliar with Park, noting that Soo Sunny Park is a Korean American artist and that the 2013 work consists of colorful prisms formed by light passing through iridescent tiles.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The sentence describes aspects of Unwoven Light but doesn't mention who Park is; it thus doesn't effectively describe the work to an audience unfamiliar with Park.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Park's 2013 installation Unwoven Light, which included a chain-link fence and iridescent tiles made from plexiglass, featured light as its primary medium of expression.	Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes aspects of Unwoven Light but doesn't mention who Park is; it thus doesn't effectively describe the work to an audience unfamiliar with Park.
X B	Korean American light artist Soo Sunny Park created Unwoven Light in 2013.	Choice B is incorrect. Although the sentence indicates when the work was created and who Park is, it lacks descriptive details and thus doesn't effectively describe Unwoven Light.
X C	The chain-link fence in Soo Sunny Park's Unwoven Light was fitted with tiles made from iridescent plexiglass.	Choice C is incorrect. The sentence mentions Park and describes an aspect of Unwoven Light—the chain-link fence—but doesn't effectively describe the overall work to an audience unfamiliar with the artist.
✓ D	In Unwoven Light, a 2013 work by Korean American artist Soo Sunny Park, light formed colorful prisms as it passed through a fence Park had fitted with iridescent tiles.	Choice D is the best answer. The sentence effectively describes Unwoven Light to an audience unfamiliar with Park, noting that Soo Sunny Park is a Korean American artist and that the 2013 work consists of colorful prisms formed by light passing through iridescent tiles.

Question 4

Medium

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In meteorology, an air mass is a large body of air with generally uniform humidity and temperature.
- Air masses are commonly classified by two-letter names.
- The first letter indicates the humidity of the air mass, while the second letter indicates the temperature. cA (continental arctic) means dry and cold, for example. mT (maritime tropical) means moist and warm.
- This classification system is based on the work of a Swedish meteorologist named Tor Bergeron (1891–1977).

The student wants to provide an example of an air mass. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** Air masses are large bodies of air with generally uniform humidity and temperature.
- B.** The air mass classification system uses two-letter names and is based on the work of Tor Bergeron, a Swedish meteorologist.
- C.** Air masses are commonly classified by a two-letter name that indicates humidity and temperature.
- D.** One type of air mass is known as a cA, or continental arctic, air mass because it is dry and cold.

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is D. The sentence provides an example of an air mass: the cA, or continental arctic, air mass.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The sentence provides a general definition of air masses; it doesn't provide an example of a specific air mass.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Air masses are large bodies of air with generally uniform humidity and temperature.	Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides a general definition of air masses; it doesn't provide an example of a specific air mass.
X B	The air mass classification system uses two-letter names and is based on the work of Tor Bergeron, a Swedish meteorologist.	Choice B is incorrect. The sentence describes the system used to classify air masses; it doesn't provide an example of a specific air mass.
X C	Air masses are commonly classified by a two-letter name that indicates humidity and temperature.	Choice C is incorrect. The sentence explains how air masses are classified; it doesn't provide an example of a specific air mass.
✓ D	One type of air mass is known as a cA, or continental arctic, air mass because it is dry and cold.	Choice D is the best answer. The sentence provides an example of an air mass: the cA, or continental arctic, air mass.

Question 5

Medium

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Heartbeat of Wounded Knee: Native America from 1890 to the Present is a history book by Ojibwe author David Treuer.
- In a review, a critic for The Economist noted that “Treuer’s storytelling skills shine” and that the book is an “elegant handling of [a] complex narrative.” A critic for O, The Oprah Magazine called it “a marvel of research and storytelling.” A critic for the Missoulian dubbed it “a monumental achievement.”

The student wants to emphasize a similarity in how critics responded to Treuer’s book. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** Treuer’s book, which was widely reviewed, focuses on Native American history from 1890 to the present.
- B.** Dubbed “a monumental achievement” by the Missoulian, Treuer’s book documents over a century of Native American history.
- C.** Critics praised Treuer’s book for its compelling narrative, with O, The Oprah Magazine calling it “a marvel of research and storytelling” and The Economist likewise writing that “Treuer’s storytelling skills shine” and that the book is an “elegant handling of [a] complex narrative.”
- D.** While the Missoulian focused on the book’s broader achievement, The Economist zeroed in on Treuer’s storytelling skills.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is C. The sentence emphasizes a similarity in how critics responded to Treuer's book, noting that the critics for *O, The Oprah Magazine* and *The Economist* both praised the book's storytelling.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The sentence provides background information about Treuer's book; it doesn't emphasize a similarity in how critics responded to it.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Treuer's book, which was widely reviewed, focuses on Native American history from 1890 to the present.	Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides background information about Treuer's book; it doesn't emphasize a similarity in how critics responded to it.
X B	Dubbed "a monumental achievement" by the Missoulian, Treuer's book documents over a century of Native American history.	Choice B is incorrect. The sentence cites a single critic's response to Treuer's book; it doesn't emphasize a similarity in the responses of multiple critics.
✓ C	Critics praised Treuer's book for its compelling narrative, with O, The Oprah Magazine calling it "a marvel of research and storytelling" and The Economist likewise writing that "Treuer's storytelling skills shine" and that the book is an "elegant handling of [a] complex narrative."	Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity in how critics responded to Treuer's book, noting that the critics for O, The Oprah Magazine and The Economist both praised the book's storytelling.
X D	While the Missoulian focused on the book's broader achievement, The Economist zeroed in on Treuer's storytelling skills.	Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a difference, not a similarity, in how two critics responded to Treuer's book.

Question 6

Hard

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 1978, Sámi activists staged protests to block the construction of a dam on the Alta River in Norway.
- The dam would disrupt Sámi fishing and reindeer herding.
- The dam was ultimately built, but the Alta conflict had a lasting impact.
- It brought international attention to the issue of Sámi rights.
- It led to a set of 2005 legal protections establishing Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about the Alta conflict. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** During the Alta conflict, Sámi activists staged protests to block the construction of a dam on the Alta River in Norway that would disrupt local fishing and reindeer herding.
- B.** Although the dam that the Sámi activists had protested was ultimately built, the Alta conflict had a lasting impact.
- C.** Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources received international attention and legal protections as a result of the Alta conflict.
- D.** The Alta conflict had a lasting impact, resulting in international attention and legal protections for Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is D. It makes a generalization—the conflict had a lasting impact—and then supports it with evidence—the attention and protections were results of the conflict.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: This choice doesn't make a generalization about the conflict. It describes a specific event from the conflict.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	During the Alta conflict, Sámi activists staged protests to block the construction of a dam on the Alta River in Norway that would disrupt local fishing and reindeer herding.	Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn't make a generalization about the conflict. It describes a specific event from the conflict.
X B	Although the dam that the Sámi activists had protested was ultimately built, the Alta conflict had a lasting impact.	Choice B is incorrect. This choice makes a generalization about the Alta conflict, but doesn't support it.
X C	Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources received international attention and legal protections as a result of the Alta conflict.	Choice C is incorrect. This choice makes a statement about the aftermath of the conflict, but doesn't support it. The statement is also a little too specific to be a generalization.
✓ D	The Alta conflict had a lasting impact, resulting in international attention and legal protections for Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources.	Choice D is the best answer. It makes a generalization—the conflict had a lasting impact—and then supports it with evidence—the attention and protections were results of the conflict.

Question 7

Hard

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The National Congress of American Indians (NCAI) was founded in 1944 by representatives of fifty tribal governments.
- The NCAI was created to protect the sovereignty of Indigenous tribes.
- Napoleon B. Johnson (Cherokee) was the NCAI's first president.
- In 1975, the US Congress passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act (Public Law 96-638).
- This legislation formally acknowledged tribes' right to self-governance.
- The advocacy of the NCAI was a key factor in the law's passing.

The student wants to identify an accomplishment of the NCAI. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** The NCAI, founded by representatives of fifty tribal governments, had Napoleon B. Johnson (Cherokee) as its first president.
- B.** Founded in 1944, the NCAI was created by representatives of tribal governments from fifty sovereign Indigenous tribes.
- C.** The NCAI's advocacy was key to the passing of Public Law 96-638, legislation formally acknowledging Indigenous tribes' right to self-governance.
- D.** In 1975, the NCAI passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act, which was created to protect the sovereignty of Indigenous tribes.

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is C. The sentence directly identifies an accomplishment of the NCAI: that its advocacy was key to the passing of Public Law 96-638, which formally acknowledged Indigenous tribes' right to self-governance.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The sentence provides information about the NCAI's founding and its first president, but it doesn't identify an accomplishment of the organization.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	The NCAI, founded by representatives of fifty tribal governments, had Napoleon B. Johnson (Cherokee) as its first president.	Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides information about the NCAI's founding and its first president, but it doesn't identify an accomplishment of the organization.
X B	Founded in 1944, the NCAI was created by representatives of tribal governments from fifty sovereign Indigenous tribes.	Choice B is incorrect. The sentence describes the NCAI's founding, but it doesn't identify an accomplishment of the organization.
✓ C	The NCAI's advocacy was key to the passing of Public Law 96-638, legislation formally acknowledging Indigenous tribes' right to self-governance.	Choice C is the best answer. The sentence directly identifies an accomplishment of the NCAI: that its advocacy was key to the passing of Public Law 96-638, which formally acknowledged Indigenous tribes' right to self-governance.
X D	In 1975, the NCAI passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act, which was created to protect the sovereignty of Indigenous tribes.	Choice D is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents the information in the notes: the US Congress, not the NCAI, passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act.

Question 8

Hard

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Gullah are a group of African Americans who have lived in parts of the southeastern United States since the 18th century.
- Gullah culture is influenced by West African and Central African traditions.
- Louise Miller Cohen is a Gullah historian, storyteller, and preservationist.
- She founded the Gullah Museum of Hilton Head Island, South Carolina, in 2003.
- Vermelle Rodrigues is a Gullah historian, artist, and preservationist.
- She founded the Gullah Museum of Georgetown, South Carolina, in 2003.

The student wants to emphasize the duration and purpose of Cohen’s and Rodrigues’s work. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** At the Gullah Museums in Hilton Head Island and Georgetown, South Carolina, visitors can learn more about the Gullah people who have lived in the region for centuries.
- B.** Louise Miller Cohen and Vermelle Rodrigues have worked to preserve the culture of the Gullah people, who have lived in the United States since the 18th century.
- C.** Since 2003, Louise Miller Cohen and Vermelle Rodrigues have worked to preserve Gullah culture through their museums.
- D.** Influenced by the traditions of West and Central Africa, Gullah culture developed in parts of the southeastern United States in the 18th century.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is C. The sentence emphasizes both the duration (the length of time) and the purpose of Cohen's and Rodrigues's work by noting that the women have been working since 2003 to preserve Gullah culture.

Rule

The correct choice must use only information stated in the notes, and it must accomplish the exact task named in the final sentence — not a nearby or related task.

Tip

Check every choice against the stated goal word-for-word — a choice can be well-written and factually accurate and still fail the task if it doesn't accomplish exactly what the student wants to do.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: While the sentence emphasizes what visitors to Cohen's and Rodrigues's museums can learn, it doesn't mention the duration or purpose of the women's work.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	At the Gullah Museums in Hilton Head Island and Georgetown, South Carolina, visitors can learn more about the Gullah people who have lived in the region for centuries.	Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes what visitors to Cohen's and Rodrigues's museums can learn, it doesn't mention the duration or purpose of the women's work.
X B	Louise Miller Cohen and Vermelle Rodrigues have worked to preserve the culture of the Gullah people, who have lived in the United States since the 18th century.	Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes the purpose of Cohen's and Rodrigues's work, it doesn't mention the duration of that work (the length of time the women have been working to preserve Gullah culture).
✓ C	Since 2003, Louise Miller Cohen and Vermelle Rodrigues have worked to preserve Gullah culture through their museums.	Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes both the duration (the length of time) and the purpose of Cohen's and Rodrigues's work by noting that the women have been working since 2003 to preserve Gullah culture.
X D	Influenced by the traditions of West and Central Africa, Gullah culture developed in parts of the southeastern United States in the 18th century.	Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes where and when Gullah culture developed, it doesn't mention the duration or purpose of Cohen's and Rodrigues's work.

Three Rules

- No new information — use only what is in the notes.
- No specific detail unless it directly serves the stated task.
- Read the question carefully — the answer must match the exact purpose stated.

SECTION 2

Transitions

Theory + 11 Worked Questions

Transitions

Transition questions ask you to choose the word or phrase that best connects two ideas by expressing the correct logical relationship. Some questions present a single missing word; increasingly, the Digital SAT presents full alternative sentences as the answer choices rather than a one-word blank.

What the Real Data Shows

By the numbers — from 114 real Transitions questions

"However" is not the most-tested word. It appears as an answer CHOICE in only 15% of Transitions questions (17 of 114) — and when it does appear, it is the CORRECT answer just 12% of the time (2 of 17). Far more often, "however" is sitting there as the trap.

The two most frequently CORRECT transitions in the real bank are "specifically" (10 times) and "by contrast" (9 times)

61% of correct answers are a single word. Only 11% are long, three-or-more-word phrases. The Digital SAT has genuinely increased its use of longer transitional phrases in recent forms, but a single confident word is still the most common right answer by far — don't over-correct toward expecting a long phrase every time.

The takeaway: memorizing "however" as your default contrast word is a weaker strategy than actually labeling the relationship between the two sentences. The method below works regardless of which specific word or phrase ends up being correct.

The Seven Categories

Every transition on the exam falls into one of seven distinct categories. Learn to recognize the RELATIONSHIP first — the category — and the right word follows naturally.

Continuation The second idea adds to, agrees with, or builds on the first — both ideas move in the same direction. Nothing is being challenged or limited; the second sentence simply extends or reinforces the first. Common words: <i>furthermore, moreover, additionally, in addition, also, indeed, in fact, similarly, likewise</i>	Cause-Effect One idea directly produces, explains, or logically results from the other. There must be a genuine causal link, not just two events that happen to be related — check that the first sentence actually explains why the second one is true. Common words: <i>therefore, thus, hence, consequently, accordingly, thereby, as such, ergo, for this reason</i>
Contrast The second idea opposes, limits, or reverses the first. This is the broadest category, covering everything from a flat contradiction to a partial concession — see the "However" deep-dive for how much nuance a single contrast word can carry. Common words: <i>however, nevertheless, yet, though, conversely, by contrast, on the contrary, whereas, that said, granted</i>	Sequence / Time One event follows another in TIME, with no causal claim being made. This is the category students most often confuse with Cause-Effect — "subsequently" tells you WHEN something happened, never WHY. Common words: <i>subsequently, then, meanwhile, thereafter, henceforth, hitherto, heretofore</i>

The Seven Categories (cont.)

Clarification The second idea restates, narrows, or gives a concrete example of the first, rather than adding new information. If the second sentence could be read as "what I mean by that is...," this is the category. Common words: <i>specifically, in particular, for example, for instance, in other words, that is</i>	Degree The transition limits HOW FAR or IN WHAT WAY a statement is true, rather than adding, contrasting, or explaining. A narrower, less common category — but real bank data shows "to that end" alone appeared 3 times as a correct answer. Common words: <i>insofar as, inasmuch as, to that end, of course</i>
Mechanism The transition names the METHOD or PROCESS that enables something to happen. This category has essentially one word worth knowing on the exam — but it is worth knowing, since nothing else in the other six categories can substitute for it. Common words: <i>whereby</i>	

A Reliable 4-Step Method

- Ignore the answer choices first. This prevents being tricked by a word that sounds academic but doesn't match the logic.
- Read the sentence before and the sentence after the blank. Ask: similar? opposite? one explaining the other? a shift in focus?
- Label the relationship using one of the seven categories above.
- Match your label to the correct transition — not the most impressive-sounding one.

The most common mistake

Choosing a transition that sounds sophisticated instead of the one that matches the actual logic. The real exam consistently includes at least one formal-sounding wrong answer designed to catch students who pattern-match on tone rather than relationship.

"However" — Three Uses, Explained in Full

- "However" is the single most conceptually important contrast word on the exam, even though it is tested less often than most students assume (see the data above).
- It deserves this much attention because it covers three genuinely different logical situations, and the exam exploits that range to build wrong answers that "sound right" but signal the wrong one of the three.
- "However" ALWAYS signals that the second idea moves in a different direction from the first. What changes between the three uses is HOW DIFFERENT that direction is, and WHY the difference matters.
- Getting this distinction right is what separates a student who has memorized "however = contrast" from one who can tell when a more precise word — "nevertheless," "that said," "on the contrary" — is correct instead.

Use 1 — Simple contrast (two opposing facts, no surprise)

- The first sentence states one fact. The second states a different or opposing fact.
- Neither fact is surprising on its own — they simply point in different directions, and "however" exists purely to flag that shift for the reader.

"However" — Three Uses, Explained in Full (cont.)

"The museum recently expanded its collection of modern sculptures. However, attendance has dropped significantly over the past year."

- Neither fact here contradicts an expectation set up earlier in the text — the passage never claimed the expanded collection WOULD increase attendance.
- The two facts are just placed side by side, and "however" marks that they don't point the same way.

"The factory increased its output by 30 percent last year. However, its profit margin remained essentially flat."

Use 2 — Reversal of expectation (new evidence overturns an old belief)

- The first sentence sets up a belief, hypothesis, or expectation — often using words like "believed," "assumed," "thought," or "predicted."
- The second sentence introduces new evidence that directly contradicts or undermines that expectation — the "plot twist" use, favored when the passage has a research or discovery angle.

"However" — Three Uses, Explained in Full (cont.)

"Researchers initially believed the exoplanet had conditions suitable for liquid water. However, recent analyses reveal an atmosphere composed almost entirely of hydrogen and helium."

- The giveaway is the verb of belief in sentence one ("believed") paired with a verb of discovery in sentence two ("reveal").
- When you see that pattern, "however" (or a synonym like "yet" or "in fact") is almost always what belongs in the blank.

"Economists long assumed that automation would reduce total employment. However, several recent studies find no significant net job loss in automated industries."

Use 3 — Concession (both things are true; the second one limits the first)

- This is the use students most often get wrong, because it doesn't feel like a "real" contrast — both sentences can be true AT THE SAME TIME.
- The second sentence isn't denying the first; it's narrowing where or how far the first sentence applies.

"The program has produced strong results in urban schools. However, rural districts have seen little improvement under the same conditions."

"However" — Three Uses, Explained in Full (cont.)

- The program's success and its failure in rural districts are both simultaneously true — "however" here signals "yes, but only in some places," not "that's wrong."
- Concession IS a form of disagreement, just a partial one — don't wrongly eliminate "however" on the reasoning that "the passage doesn't really disagree with itself."

"The new policy has reduced emissions across most sectors. However, the transportation sector has shown almost no measurable change."

The overarching rule for all three uses

If the two sentences point in the SAME direction — one adds to, agrees with, or supports the other — "however" is automatically wrong, no matter how well it seems to fit tonally. Use "furthermore" or "moreover" instead.

If they point in different directions, ask which of the three uses applies — that tells you whether "however" itself is correct, or whether a more specific word (like "nevertheless" for Use 3, or "yet" for Use 2) is what the exam actually wants.

"Though" — Three Positions, Explained in Full

"Though" is unusual among transitions because the SAME word changes grammatical function depending on where it sits in the sentence. At the start or in the middle, it works as a conjunction — identical in meaning to "although." At the end, it switches to an adverb — identical in meaning to "however." This is exactly the kind of nuance the exam likes to test, because a student who only knows "though = although" will miss the end-of-sentence use entirely.

Position 1 — Start of sentence (conjunction, = although)

"Though" introduces a subordinate clause that states a concession. The main clause — the sentence's real point — follows.

"Though the experiment produced unexpected results, the researchers considered it a success."

The concession (unexpected results) comes first; the main point (still a success) follows. You could substitute "Although" here with zero change in meaning.

Position 2 — Middle of sentence (conjunction, = although)

Same grammatical function as Position 1, just reordered: the main clause comes first, and "though" introduces the qualifying clause that follows it.

"The policy was eventually adopted, though several members of the committee remained opposed."

The main fact (policy adopted) is stated first and qualified by the contrasting detail. Functionally identical to "although" or "even though" — only the sentence order changes.

Position 3 — End of sentence (adverb, = however / nevertheless)

This is the position students most often miss. When "though" sits at the very end of a sentence, set off by a comma, it is no longer introducing a clause at all — it functions as a standalone adverb meaning "however." This is informal in register but fully tested on the Digital SAT.

"The documentary was long. It was thoroughly researched and engaging, though."

Here "though" adds a gentle, trailing contrast to what was just said — the length was a drawback, but the quality compensated. Rewriting with "however" at the start of the second sentence produces the identical meaning: "The documentary was long. However, it was thoroughly researched and engaging."

Position 2 — Middle of sentence (conjunction, = although) (cont.)

"Though" vs. "Although" — the test-taking distinction

"Although" is more formal and can NEVER sit at the end of a sentence — that restriction alone can eliminate it as a wrong answer choice. "Though" can appear at the start, middle, or end.

If "though" is an answer choice, the very first thing to check is its position in the given sentence — that position alone tells you which of the three uses is being tested, before you even evaluate the logic.

Longer Transitions

A growing share of recent Digital SAT forms present multi-word transitional PHRASES as answer choices instead of a single word — "For this reason," "In light of this," "Beyond the simple coining of a term," rather than just "Therefore," "Because," or "Beyond." The real bank shows this is still the minority pattern (11% of correct answers are three-plus words, versus 61% single-word), but when a long phrase IS correct, it usually means every choice on that question is a full phrase, which changes how you should read the choices.

Why longer transitions feel harder — and how to neutralize that

A long phrase carries more surface content than a single word, which tempts you to evaluate it on WHETHER IT'S TRUE rather than whether it signals the right RELATIONSHIP. But a long transition still belongs to exactly one of the same seven categories as a single-word transition — it is just dressed in more words. "For this reason," is Cause-Effect, full stop, the same category as "therefore." Strip the phrase down to its logical core before judging it.

Common long-transition patterns by category

- Cause-Effect: "For this reason," / "As a result of this," / "In light of this," / "With this in mind,"
- Contrast: "Despite this," / "In spite of this," / "On the contrary," / "Contrary to this belief,"

Longer Transitions (cont.)

- Continuation: "Building on this idea," / "In keeping with this," / "Beyond this," / "In a similar vein,"
- Clarification: "To put it another way," / "In other words," / "More specifically," / "To that end,"

Reading strategy for long-transition questions

Cover the second half of each choice with your hand or eye and read only the first two or three words — often enough to identify the category (Despite = contrast, As a result = cause). Confirm with the full phrase only after you've narrowed to one or two candidates.

Watch for a choice that is accurate in CONTENT but wrong in RELATIONSHIP — a common trap pairs a true-sounding elaboration with the wrong logical connector, banking on you approving of the content without checking the connector itself.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Longer Transitions — 3 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Medium

Observing that a fire in a closed container soon went out, leading eighteenth-century scientists did not conclude that fresh air (specifically, oxygen) is necessary for combustion; instead, many theorized that the container's air had become saturated with a substance called phlogiston.

_____ when Joseph Priestley first isolated oxygen gas in 1774, he termed it “dephlogisticated air.”

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A.** In other words,
- B.** For this reason,
- C.** Alternatively,
- D.** Nevertheless,

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is B. "For this reason" logically signals that the reason Joseph Priestley termed oxygen "dephlogisticated air" was that he accepted the theory mentioned in the previous sentence—that the presence of phlogiston, rather than the absence of oxygen, causes fire in a closed container to go out.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: "in other words" illogically signals that the information about Priestley terming oxygen "dephlogisticated air" is a restatement of the previous theory concerning phlogiston. Instead, Priestley chose the term as a result of this theory.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	In other words,	Choice A is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the information about Priestley terming oxygen "dephlogisticated air" is a restatement of the previous theory concerning phlogiston. Instead, Priestley chose the term as a result of this theory.
✓ B	For this reason,	Choice B is the best answer. "For this reason" logically signals that the reason Joseph Priestley termed oxygen "dephlogisticated air" was that he accepted the theory mentioned in the previous sentence—that the presence of phlogiston, rather than the absence of oxygen, causes fire in a closed container to go out.
X C	Alternatively,	Choice C is incorrect because "alternatively" illogically signals that Priestley termed oxygen "dephlogisticated air" as an alternative to the previous theory concerning phlogiston. Instead, Priestley chose the term as a result of this theory.
X D	Nevertheless,	Choice D is incorrect because "nevertheless" illogically signals that Priestley termed oxygen "dephlogisticated air" despite the previous theory concerning phlogiston. Instead, Priestley chose the term as a result of this theory.

Question 2

Hard

Upon first approaching artist Kurt Wenner's *Dies Irae*, a colorful scene painted on the surface of a cobblestone street in Mantua, Italy, one might assume a deep hole filled with life-sized, classically styled sculptures had opened up in the street. _____ by expertly applying the principles of perspective, Wenner created merely the illusion of depth.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A.** Additionally,
- B.** On the contrary,
- C.** As a result,
- D.** Next,

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is B. "On the contrary" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Dies Irae's appearance of depth is merely an illusion—contrasts with the previous statement about a viewer's possible assumption regarding the street painting.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: "additionally" illogically signals that this sentence is simply additional information about a viewer's possible assumption regarding the street painting. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence's description of the illusion.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Additionally,	Choice A is incorrect because "additionally" illogically signals that this sentence is simply additional information about a viewer’s possible assumption regarding the street painting. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence’s description of the illusion.
✓ B	On the contrary,	Choice B is the best answer. "On the contrary" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Dies Irae’s appearance of depth is merely an illusion—contrasts with the previous statement about a viewer’s possible assumption regarding the street painting.
X C	As a result,	Choice C is incorrect because "as a result" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of, or caused by, a viewer’s possible assumption regarding the street painting. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence’s description of the illusion.
X D	Next,	Choice D is incorrect because "next" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is the next step in a process. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence’s description of the illusion.

Question 3

Medium

Karel Čapek’s 1920 play R.U.R. (Rossum’s Universal Robots), in which artificial workers overthrow their masters, left an indelible mark on the science fiction genre, and the English language, by introducing the term “robot” (derived from the Czech word *robota*, meaning “indentured labor” or “drudgery”). _____ Čapek’s play also contributed to a venerable literary and mythological tradition: using artificial beings as mirrors and foils for humanity.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A.** Beyond the simple coining of a term,
- B.** By achieving such a lofty goal,
- C.** Ultimately limited in its lasting influence,
- D.** Despite its creation of such an iconic trope,

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is A. “Beyond the simple coining of a term” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Čapek’s play contributed to a literary and mythological tradition of using artificial beings as mirrors and foils for humanity—describes contributions that extend beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot” to the English language.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “by achieving such a lofty goal” illogically signals that the play’s contribution to a literary and mythological tradition was accomplished through the means of the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.” Instead, the sentence describes an additional contribution that goes beyond that achievement.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Beyond the simple coining of a term,	Choice A is the best answer. “Beyond the simple coining of a term” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Čapek’s play contributed to a literary and mythological tradition of using artificial beings as mirrors and foils for humanity—describes contributions that extend beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot” to the English language.
✗ B	By achieving such a lofty goal,	Choice B is incorrect because “by achieving such a lofty goal” illogically signals that the play’s contribution to a literary and mythological tradition was accomplished through the means of the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.” Instead, the sentence describes an additional contribution that goes beyond that achievement.
✗ C	Ultimately limited in its lasting influence,	Choice C is incorrect because “ultimately limited in its lasting influence” illogically minimizes the play’s influence, which is inconsistent with the text’s other claims about the play. Instead, the sentence describes contributions that go beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.”
✗ D	Despite its creation of such an iconic trope,	Choice D is incorrect because “despite its creation of such an iconic trope” illogically signals that the play’s contribution to a literary and mythological tradition is surprising given the play’s creation of an iconic trope. Instead, the sentence describes contributions that go beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.”

Common Transition Traps

- However vs. Therefore — students default to "however" automatically. Always check whether the relationship is contrast or cause-and-effect before choosing.
- Moreover vs. However — "Moreover" adds in the same direction. If the second sentence contradicts the first, you need a contrast word instead.
- Indeed vs. For example — "Indeed" strengthens a claim; "for example" introduces a specific illustration. They are not interchangeable.
- Meanwhile — means "at the same time," full stop. It is never a contrast word, even though it's often placed among the choices specifically to bait a "however"-shaped answer.
- Specifically / In particular — narrows or focuses on one aspect of what was just said. Not addition, not contrast — despite being the single most common correct answer in the real bank, it's frequently overlooked in study guides.
- By contrast vs. However — both signal contrast, but "by contrast" more often introduces a direct, structured comparison between two named things, while "however" can bridge a looser contrast. When both appear as choices, check whether the sentence sets up an explicit two-sided comparison.

Formal Transition Reference

The words below appear less often but are worth knowing cold, since the exam typically includes exactly one formal or unusual option among the choices to test whether you're matching logic rather than memorizing common words. Grouped by the same seven categories as the reference table above.

CONTINUATION

Indeed

"Indeed" has four uses: showing agreement ("Are you coming?" — "I am indeed."), adding emphasis, strengthening a previous statement, and expressing certainty.

"My friend is remarkable. Indeed, she might be one of the best people I know."

"The weather is cold today. It is indeed freezing."

In fact

Three uses: adding stronger detail, correcting an assumption, or emphasizing truth. Most common at the start of a sentence, though it can sit mid-sentence or informally at the end.

"She passed her driving test; in fact, she is now taking an advanced course."

"That sounds simple, but in fact it is very difficult."

CONTRAST / CONCESSION

Albeit

"Although / even though." Introduces a phrase, not a full independent clause — always mid-sentence, after a comma.

"She accepted the offer, albeit reluctantly."

"The plan worked, albeit imperfectly."

Notwithstanding

"Despite / in spite of." Works as a preposition (most common), a conjunction, or — rarely — an adverb.

"Notwithstanding the rain, the event continued."

"The plan was risky; they approved it, notwithstanding."

Granted

Admits something is true before presenting a contrasting idea — acknowledges a point before the counterpoint.

"Granted, the task is simple, but it still takes time."

"Granted that the story is true, there is not much you can do."

Conversely

A strict logical opposite — stronger and more specific than a general contrast. Use when two sides of the same situation are being directly compared.

"Most people see winter as depressing. Conversely, I find it peaceful."

"High demand increases prices. Conversely, low demand pushes prices down."

That said

A conversational equivalent of "however" or "nevertheless" — softens or qualifies the previous statement.

"The exam was difficult. That said, most students passed."

"The hotel was expensive. That said, the service was excellent."

On the contrary

A stronger, more direct rejection than "however" — used when the second statement doesn't just differ from the first but actively refutes it.

""You must be disappointed." "On the contrary, I couldn't be happier.""

"The results were not disappointing. On the contrary, they exceeded every projection."

CAUSE-AND-EFFECT

Hence

"For this reason." Formal; shows logical consequence.

"He did not study; hence, he failed the exam."

"The company expanded rapidly, hence the need for more staff."

Thus

"Therefore / as a result / in this way." Formal, common after a semicolon.

"The evidence was weak; thus, the case was dismissed."

"Mix the ingredients thoroughly; thus, you ensure a smooth batter."

As such

Either "therefore" (showing consequence) or "in that capacity" (referring to a role). Usually opens the second sentence, often after a semicolon or full stop.

"The instructions were unclear; as such, many students made mistakes."

"She is the team leader, and as such, she makes the final decision."

Thereby

"By that / because of that." One action directly causes another.

"She forgot to set her alarm, thereby missing the bus."

"The treaty was signed, thereby ending the conflict."

Ergo

"Therefore." Formal, philosophical, occasionally used for deliberate rhetorical effect.

"All humans are mortal; Socrates is human; ergo, Socrates is mortal."

SEQUENCE / TIME

Hitherto

"Until now / up to this point." Implies a change is coming.

"The company had hitherto focused on local markets, but now it is expanding globally."

Heretofore

"Until now / previously." Especially common in legal and contract language.

"All documents heretofore submitted will be reviewed by the committee."

Henceforth

"From this point forward." Marks a change that applies going forward.

"The library will henceforth close at 8 p.m."

Thereafter

"After that time / from that point onward." Marks a point in time and what follows it.

"The law was passed in 2022; thereafter, all companies had to comply."

DEGREE

Insofar as

"To the extent that." Introduces a clause explaining how much or in what way something is true.

"The policy is effective insofar as it reduces unnecessary spending."

Inasmuch as

Either "because / since" (cause) or "to the extent that" (degree), depending on context.

"Inasmuch as funding is not available, building plans have been delayed."

Thereafter (cont.)

"They abide by the rules only inasmuch as it suits them."

To that end

"With that goal in mind." Introduces an action taken specifically to achieve the purpose just stated — appeared 3 times as a correct answer in the real bank, more often than several classic textbook transitions.

"The school wants to raise reading scores. To that end, it has hired two new literacy coaches."

MECHANISM

Whereby

"By which / through which." Explains the method or process that enables something — formal, common in descriptions of systems, contracts, and rules.

"The company has a scheme whereby employees can borrow money interest-free."

Thereafter (cont.)

CLC

"A new system was introduced whereby all employees must undergo regular training."

WORKED QUESTIONS

Transitions — Worked Questions by Category

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

TRANSITIONS — WORKED QUESTIONS BY CATEGORY

CONTRAST — 2 questions

Question 4

Hard

The mineral mtorolite is most commonly found in Zimbabwe. Mtorolite is cryptocrystalline, meaning that its crystalline structure is so fine that the individual crystals cannot be distinguished by the naked eye or even under a microscope. The crystals in microcrystalline minerals are also not visible to the naked eye; _____ they can usually be seen under a microscope.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A. thus,

B. for example,

C. that said,

D. similarly,

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is C. "that said" logically signals that the information that follows—that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals can be seen with a microscope—is an exception to the previous information about the crystalline structure of minerals not being visible under a microscope.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: "thus" illogically signals that the information that follows is a direct result or consequence of the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	thus,	Choice A is incorrect because "thus" illogically signals that the information that follows is a direct result or consequence of the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals.
X B	for example,	Choice B is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information that follows exemplifies the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals.
✓ C	that said,	Choice C is the best answer because "that said" logically signals that the information that follows—that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals can be seen with a microscope—is an exception to the previous information about the crystalline structure of minerals not being visible under a microscope.
X D	similarly,	Choice D is incorrect because "similarly" illogically signals that the information that follows is similar or comparable to the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals.

Question 5

Medium

Despite its great distance from Earth—it is 570 light-years away—the star Shaula is one of the brightest stars in the sky, ranking 23rd. Although not as bright as Shaula, the star Alkaid also ranks among the 50 brightest stars (40th, to be exact). _____ Alkaid’s brightness is likely due to the star’s relative proximity: Alkaid is only 100 light-years from Earth.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A. Indeed,

B. As a result,

C. Granted,

D. Similarly,

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is C. “Granted” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Alkaid’s brightness is likely due to its relative proximity to Earth—is a concession acknowledging that the star likely appears bright for different reasons than the faraway star to which it is compared, Shaula.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “indeed” illogically signals that the information in this sentence offers additional emphasis in support of the previous information about Alkaid ranking among the 50 brightest stars. Instead, the sentence concedes that the most likely reason Alkaid is counted among the sky’s brightest stars is its relative proximity to Earth.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Indeed,	Choice A is incorrect because “indeed” illogically signals that the information in this sentence offers additional emphasis in support of the previous information about Alkaid ranking among the 50 brightest stars. Instead, the sentence concedes that the most likely reason Alkaid is counted among the sky’s brightest stars is its relative proximity to Earth.
X B	As a result,	Choice B is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that Alkaid’s brightness is caused by the previous information about Alkaid ranking among the 50 brightest stars. Instead, the sentence concedes that the most likely reason Alkaid is counted among the sky’s brightest stars is its relative proximity to Earth.
✓ C	Granted,	Choice C is the best answer. “Granted” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Alkaid’s brightness is likely due to its relative proximity to Earth—is a concession acknowledging that the star likely appears bright for different reasons than the faraway star to which it is compared, Shaula.
X D	Similarly,	Choice D is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous information about Alkaid ranking among the 50 brightest stars. Instead, the sentence concedes that the most likely reason Alkaid is counted among the sky’s brightest stars is its relative proximity to Earth.

TRANSITIONS — WORKED QUESTIONS BY CATEGORY

CAUSE-EFFECT — 2 questions

Question 6

Medium

In 2019, researcher Patricia Jurado Gonzalez and food historian Nawal Nasrallah prepared a stew from a 4,000-year-old recipe found on a Mesopotamian clay tablet. When they tasted the dish, known as pašrūtum (“unwinding”), they found that it had a mild taste and inspired a sense of calm. _____ the researchers, knowing that dishes were sometimes named after their intended effects, theorized that the dish’s name, “unwinding,” referred to its function: to help ancient diners relax.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A.** Therefore,
- B.** Alternately,
- C.** Nevertheless,
- D.** Likewise,

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is A. "Therefore" logically signals that the action described in this sentence—the researchers theorizing that the dish was named for its effect on diners—is a result or consequence of the previous observation that the dish had a calming effect.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: "alternately" illogically signals that the action described in this sentence offers an alternative or contrast to the previous observation that the dish had a calming effect. Instead, the action is a result or consequence of that observation.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Therefore,	Choice A is the best answer. "Therefore" logically signals that the action described in this sentence—the researchers theorizing that the dish was named for its effect on diners—is a result or consequence of the previous observation that the dish had a calming effect.
✗ B	Alternately,	Choice B is incorrect because "alternately" illogically signals that the action described in this sentence offers an alternative or contrast to the previous observation that the dish had a calming effect. Instead, the action is a result or consequence of that observation.
✗ C	Nevertheless,	Choice C is incorrect because "nevertheless" illogically signals that the action described in this sentence occurs despite the previous observation that the dish had a calming effect. Instead, the action is a result or consequence of that observation.
✗ D	Likewise,	Choice D is incorrect because "likewise" illogically signals that this sentence merely adds a second, similar detail to the previous observation that the dish had a calming effect. Instead, this sentence describes an action that is a result or consequence of that observation.

Question 7

Medium

Although those who migrated to California in 1849 dreamed of finding gold nuggets in streambeds, the state's richest deposits were buried deeply in rock, beyond the reach of individual prospectors. _____ by 1852, many had given up their fortune-hunting dreams and gone to work for one of the large companies capable of managing California's complex mining operations.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Furthermore,
- B. Still,
- C. Consequently,
- D. Next,

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is C. “Consequently” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that many individual gold prospectors gave up their fortune-hunting dreams and became employees of mining companies—is a result or consequence of the previous information about the inaccessibility of the state’s gold deposits.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “furthermore” illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about the inaccessibility of the state’s gold deposits. Instead, it’s a result or consequence of that information.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Furthermore,	Choice A is incorrect because “furthermore” illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about the inaccessibility of the state’s gold deposits. Instead, it’s a result or consequence of that information.
X B	Still,	Choice B is incorrect because “still” illogically signals that the information in this sentence offers a contrast or exception to the previous information about the inaccessibility of the state’s gold deposits. Instead, it’s a result or consequence of that information.
✓ C	Consequently,	Choice C is the best answer. “Consequently” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that many individual gold prospectors gave up their fortune-hunting dreams and became employees of mining companies—is a result or consequence of the previous information about the inaccessibility of the state’s gold deposits.
X D	Next,	Choice D is incorrect because “next” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is the next step in a process. Instead, it’s a result or consequence of the previous information about the inaccessibility of the state’s gold deposits.

TRANSITIONS — WORKED QUESTIONS BY CATEGORY

CONTINUATION — 2 questions

Question 8

Medium

Award-winning travel writer Linda Watanabe McFerrin considers the background research she conducts on destinations featured in her travel books to be its own reward. _____ McFerrin admits to finding the research phase of her work just as fascinating and engaging as exploring a location in person.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A. By contrast,

B. Likewise,

C. Besides,

D. In fact,

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is D. “In fact” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that McFerrin finds the research phase of her work to be just as fascinating as travel—emphasizes and elaborates on the previous sentence’s point that McFerrin regards background research as a rewarding activity.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what’s offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “by contrast” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	By contrast,	Choice A is incorrect because “by contrast” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point.
X B	Likewise,	Choice B is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that this sentence merely adds a second, similar point to the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point.
X C	Besides,	Choice C is incorrect because “besides” illogically signals that this sentence provides a separate point in addition to, or apart from, the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point.
✓ D	In fact,	Choice D is the best answer. “In fact” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that McFerrin finds the research phase of her work to be just as fascinating as travel—emphasizes and elaborates on the previous sentence’s point that McFerrin regards background research as a rewarding activity.

Question 9

Medium

In the early 1900s, Jovita Idár fought injustice on both sides of the Mexico–United States border. As a reporter for the Texas newspaper *La Crónica*, she voiced support for the Mexican people’s revolt against authoritarian rule. _____ she founded the League of Mexican Women, a group that advocated for the rights of Mexican Americans.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A.** Additionally,
- B.** In conclusion,
- C.** For example,
- D.** Rather,

Question 9 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is A. “additionally” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Idár founded the League of Mexican Women—is another instance of Idár fighting injustice, this time advocating for the rights of Mexican Americans.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “in conclusion” illogically signals that the information in this sentence sums up or concludes the discussion of Idár’s support for the Mexican people’s revolt. Instead, the founding of the League of Mexican Women is a separate instance of Idár fighting injustice.

Question 9 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Additionally,	Choice A is the best answer because “additionally” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Idár founded the League of Mexican Women—is another instance of Idár fighting injustice, this time advocating for the rights of Mexican Americans.
✗ B	In conclusion,	Choice B is incorrect because “in conclusion” illogically signals that the information in this sentence sums up or concludes the discussion of Idár’s support for the Mexican people’s revolt. Instead, the founding of the League of Mexican Women is a separate instance of Idár fighting injustice.
✗ C	For example,	Choice C is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is an example of how, as a newspaper reporter, Idár voiced support for the Mexican people’s revolt. Instead, the founding of the League of Mexican Women is a separate instance of Idár fighting injustice, this time in support of Mexican Americans.
✗ D	Rather,	Choice D is incorrect because “rather” illogically signals that the information in this sentence offers a contrast or exception to the previous information about Idár’s support for the Mexican people’s revolt. Instead, the founding of the League of Mexican Women is a separate instance of Idár fighting injustice.

TRANSITIONS — WORKED QUESTIONS BY CATEGORY

SEQUENCE — 1 question

Question 10

Medium

In 2018, Kurt Luther and Vikram Mohanty created the web-based tool Civil War Photo Sleuth (CWPS). A user uploading an unknown Civil War soldier's photograph to CWPS first tags the photo with all known information. _____ CWPS's facial-recognition software analyzes twenty-seven different physical features and looks for matches to tagged images already in the database.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A. Then,

B. In fact,

C. Likewise,

D. For example,

Question 10 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is A. “Then” indicates that the events in this sentence took place after the events in the previous sentence. Only after users upload images of unknown soldiers can those images be analyzed.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: This transition is used to emphasize the truth of a statement that modifies the previous statement. But this sentence doesn't modify the step described in the previous statement: instead, it introduces an entirely new step in the process. So “in fact” wouldn't make sense here.

Question 10 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	Then,	Choice A is the best answer. “Then” indicates that the events in this sentence took place after the events in the previous sentence. Only after users upload images of unknown soldiers can those images be analyzed.
✗ B	In fact,	Choice B is incorrect. This transition is used to emphasize the truth of a statement that modifies the previous statement. But this sentence doesn’t modify the step described in the previous statement: instead, it introduces an entirely new step in the process. So “in fact” wouldn’t make sense here.
✗ C	Likewise,	Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of a new but related idea, which doesn’t make sense here. Analyzing the physical features in the uploaded photographs isn’t a similar idea, but rather the next step in the process.
✗ D	For example,	Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses an exemplification transition, which doesn’t make sense here. Analyzing physical features is not an example of uploading and tagging an image.

TRANSITIONS — WORKED QUESTIONS BY CATEGORY

CLARIFICATION — 1 question

Question 11

Medium

Researchers believe that pieces of hull found off Oregon's coast are from a Spanish cargo ship that was lost in 1697. Stories passed down among the area's Confederated Tribes of Siletz Indians support this belief. _____ Siletz stories describe how blocks of beeswax, an item the ship had been carrying, began washing ashore after the ship was lost.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. For this reason,
- B. For example,
- C. However,
- D. Likewise,

Question 11 — Explanation

Explanation

The correct answer is B. “For example” logically signals that the Siletz beeswax stories mentioned in this sentence are examples consistent with the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory.

Rule

Identify the logical relationship between the two ideas — addition, contrast, cause-effect, sequence, or clarification — before reading the answer choices. The correct transition is the one that names that relationship precisely, not just plausibly.

Tip

Ignore the answer choices at first. Read only the sentence before and the sentence after, and decide in your own words how they relate — addition, contrast, cause, sequence, or clarification — before you look at what's offered.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “for this reason” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax were caused by the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim.

Question 11 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	For this reason,	Choice A is incorrect because “for this reason” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax were caused by the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim.
✓ B	For example,	Choice B is the best answer. “For example” logically signals that the Siletz beeswax stories mentioned in this sentence are examples consistent with the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory.
X C	However,	Choice C is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax contrast with the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim.
X D	Likewise,	Choice D is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax are similar to the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim.

At a Glance

- Step 1: Ignore the choices. Read both sentences.
- Step 2: Label the relationship — one of the seven categories.
- Step 3: Match the label to the transition type.

Remember from the data

"Specifically" and "by contrast" are tested more often than "however." Don't let familiarity with "however" crowd out the less famous words that are actually correct more often.

Master Transition Table

Word / Phrase	Type	Key meaning / tip
however	Contrast	3 uses: simple contrast, reversal of expectation, concession. Always signals the second sentence goes in a different direction.
though	Contrast	Start / middle = although. End of sentence = however. Position matters.
nevertheless	Contrast	Despite the first sentence, the second happens anyway. Stronger/more formal than "however."
conversely	Contrast	Strict logical opposite. More specific than "however."
that said	Contrast	Informal "however." Softens or qualifies the previous point.
albeit	Contrast	"Although / even though." Introduces a phrase (not a full clause) that limits the main statement. Always mid-sentence.

Master Transition Table (cont.)

Word / Phrase	Type	Key meaning / tip
notwithstanding	Contrast	"Despite / in spite of." Can be preposition, conjunction, or adverb. Very formal.
granted	Contrast	Acknowledges a truth before a counterpoint. "Granted, this is true, but..."
whereas	Contrast	Draws a direct contrast between two clauses. More formal than "but."
even so	Contrast	"Despite that." Similar to "nevertheless" but slightly less formal.
furthermore	Continuation	Adds a point going in the same direction. NOT contrast.
moreover	Continuation	Adds a stronger or more significant point in the same direction.
indeed	Continuation	Emphasises or confirms what was just said. Can strengthen a claim or show agreement.

Master Transition Table (cont.)

Word / Phrase	Type	Key meaning / tip
in fact	Continuation / Contrast	Adds stronger detail when reinforcing; corrects or surprises when contradicting. Context decides.
likewise	Continuation	"Similarly / in the same way." Draws a parallel between two situations.
therefore / thus	Cause-Effect	The second sentence is the logical result of the first. Both are formal.
hence	Cause-Effect	"For this reason." Formal. Shows a logical consequence.
consequently	Cause-Effect	"As a result." The second sentence follows directly from the first.
accordingly	Cause-Effect	"As a result / in response to that." Second sentence is a direct response to the first.
as such	Cause-Effect	"Therefore / in that capacity." Shows a logical consequence or explains a role.

Master Transition Table (cont.)

Word / Phrase	Type	Key meaning / tip
thereby	Cause-Effect	"By doing that / because of that." One action directly produces another.
ergo	Cause-Effect	"Therefore." Formal / philosophical. Draws a logical conclusion.
subsequently	Sequence	"After that." Time order only. Does NOT imply cause.
meanwhile	Sequence	"At the same time." NOT a contrast word. Frequently used as a wrong answer.
thereafter	Sequence	"After that time / from that point on." Refers back to a specific earlier moment.
henceforth	Sequence	"From this point forward." Announces a change going forward.
hitherto	Sequence	"Until now." Describes what was true up to the present. Implies a change.

Master Transition Table (cont.)

Word / Phrase	Type	Key meaning / tip
heretofore	Sequence	"Until now / previously." Formal / legal. Same direction as hitherto but more official.
insofar as	Degree	"To the extent that." Limits how far a statement is true.
inasmuch as	Cause / Degree	"Because / to the extent that." Formal. Introduces a reason or a degree of truth.
whereby	Mechanism	"By which / through which." Explains the method or process enabling something.

Well done.

Expression of Ideas: theory and worked questions complete.